

CARRY

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A Fogbound Story

By Dy'on Lindsey

Wind whipped through the dead grass around our boots, sending dry twigs rolling across the ground. I could feel the heat of the sun pressing on the back of my neck, but the sweat on my palms wasn't from the weather.

“A'ight, so we're clear on this?” Kelly asked, his voice a little too bright, like he was trying to hide something behind it. “We kill the bastard, take the reward, and then what? You want me to buy you a drink? Or are we savin' that for after we —”

I cut him off with a snort, pushing past him as I checked the bullets in my revolver. “I don’t know what you’re talkin’ about,” I said, trying to keep my tone steady. “We kill the bastard, take the reward, then I get to keep it all. You wouldn’t know what to do with it anyway.”

He snickered, then slapped me lightly on the back. “Sure, sure. I’d just blow it all on something nice for ya. Maybe a new coat. You look like you’re about to die in that thing anyway.”

I shot him a glance, a smirk tugging at the corner of my mouth. “Not all of us can afford to be as pretty as you, Miss Kelly.”

He laughed again, but it was quick, short. He cleared his throat, like the joke hadn’t quite landed. Then we both fell quiet, the kind of quiet that’s not exactly comfortable but not awkward enough to break yet.

We'd been tracking the bounty for days now. He was supposed to be here, just up ahead, hiding in a cabin somewhere near the woods. Some guy who'd messed with the things in the dark that he shouldn't have, and crossed the wrong people—people who had paid to make sure he didn't walk away from this.

I flexed my fingers on my revolver, but the weight of it in my hands felt off. Too heavy, like it wasn't supposed to be there.

“Gotta admit,” Kelly said quietly, “I thought it'd be... different.” His voice was tight, just on the edge of breaking, like he didn't want to be heard. He slammed his fist hard against his leg, took a breath. “I thought we'd have been out here killin' folk left and right by now, y'know? All that talk from the others, like it's somethin' normal.”

I stayed quiet for a moment. The sun hit my face, but it didn't feel like it was warm anymore. Just bright. "Yeah. I thought the same thing."

And then there it was, the cabin. Small and rundown, tucked back in the trees, barely visible from the main road. A shadow flickered in the light, through the window; someone pacing back and forth.

"That him?" Kelly asked, like he didn't already know the answer.

"Yeah. Looks like it." I didn't say anything else. I didn't know what else to say.

We moved closer, staying low, our boots barely making a sound against the ground. Heavy. Each step closer weighed more and more, like dragging something—something I couldn't shake.

We circled around to the back of the cabin, where the door was cracked open. Kelly's eyes were wide, scanning the area, but his face was unreadable. He hit his leg again, took a breath.

My heart beat like horse hooves as we waited, listening to the sounds inside. Faint tunes of jazz played. No doubt to calm his restlessness; the man had good taste, shame. I only wished the music could calm my own nerves.

Kelly looked at me, neither one of us wanting to give the signal. The first second was rehearsed. Inhale exhale, just like old man Gene taught us. Doing anything without a clear mind is just inviting trouble. Second number two, inhale exhale. Don't let your mind outrun your body when shit gets heavy. Second number three. Inhale. Exh—

—The music stopped; so did the man's pacing. The silence was thick, like the air itself was holding its breath.

“A'ight, here we go’,” I signaled. But before I could move, a voice cracked through the air.

“Please! Please, don’t! I beg you!”

We both froze as the man came out of the cabin. His face was pale, his hands shaking, his nails darkening. He was older than I thought, more worn out. All the signs of someone who’d been using for a while. He dropped to his knees, voice thick with panic.

How did he know we were here?

“Please! I swear I’ll make it right! Just... just don’t kill me! I’m begging you!”

Kelly’s jaw tightened, but there was something else in his eyes, something I wasn’t used to seeing. It wasn’t just nerves. Regret? I glanced over at him. He looked away quickly.

“Please,” the man begged again as he crawled toward us, tears and snot running down his face— some even in his mouth. “I’m not who you think I am! You’ve got it wrong! I never— please, please just let me go!”

And there it was—right in front of us. The reason we were out here in the first place. That first kill. The ghost of the conversation that led us here haunted me.

The dark room in the neon town, the sleazy look of the woman we’d met, and the words Old man Gene had spoken about Kelly and me, all of those ghosts were making themselves known.

“I’m more than sure they can handle it. These are the two finest I’ve ever raised.”
I’d never heard Gene speak so highly of us before. Even knowing that we’d never killed, he was still willing to give his word about us.

“Being some of your boys or not, these two look green as grass to me”, the woman said as she looked me up and down.

“You doubting my words?” That was it. That one question, that was all Gene had to say. I’d never felt a room get as heavy as when he spoke his word on something.

That’s what I want.

I refocused my mind on the man pleading for his life in front of me.

“You don’t know what I’ve had to do,” he continued through his tears.

I was supposed to pull the trigger. But all I could think about was how desperate this man looked. How much he was pleading. It was supposed to be easy, right? A job I spent years preparing to do. But it didn’t feel like that anymore. This man didn’t look twisted, evil, conniving, none of those things. He was just a man.

I tightened my grip on my revolver, but my finger stayed off the trigger. Kelly shifted beside me, and for the first time, I saw him hesitate.

He swallowed hard. “J, we– we have to. It’s the job, and we said that we would...” There was a catch in his voice, a note of uncertainty that made my stomach churn.

I nodded slowly, not saying anything, because I couldn’t. Couldn’t put words to it.

But then we both saw it– the man’s face twisted with fear, and something else. Like a recognition.

“Please, I– I can pay you. Just... just take me somewhere. Please. I just need to make it here. Please!” His words stumbled, desperate, as he pulled out a jumbled piece of paper from his pocket.

We looked at it. Plans, another cabin, and a message...

The silence that followed felt heavy, like the world itself had stopped spinning. And I knew— if we didn't do this now, we might not be able to walk away from it at all.

I met Kelly's eyes; He shook his head once.

It was the way a person shakes their head when they know they've lost control.

He aimed his revolver as I aimed mine. We pulled the triggers.

Two shots echoed through the trees, but the sound didn't feel like it belonged to us. It didn't feel like it was the end of anything.

The ride back was mostly silent. We didn't speak.

Kelly kept his eyes on the road ahead, his knuckles tight around the reins of the horse. I stared at the ground, watching the earth roll by in a blur of dirt and dust.

We didn't need to say anything. We'd both heard the man's cries. Seen the desperation in his eyes, seen the note.

Old man Gene's words ran through my memory.

"When it come time for you to get your first, do it with your relic. You gotta feel that weight."

I understood it now, we both did.

A bead of sweat dripped down my forehead, making its way to the barrel of my revolver, my handmade Relic-s1. It was heavier now.

“He was... good.” I couldn’t look at Kelly as I spoke.

“That bitch tricked us, J.”
He couldn’t look at me.

I nodded. “They... owe us.”

We didn’t say anything after that.
Felt like we were officially Gene’s.
And now, more than ever, that terrified me.

Return to the Fog

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